

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK – HIGH SCHOOL



As the town of Petersburg grew the need for a school was apparent.

The Union Church was leased by the education board, and an official school was opened in 1881.

The school was closed in April as the school master had disappeared. He had been seen in the neighbourhood, but it was reported that he was wondering around in a deranged state of mind. The council had been asked to appoint another as soon as possible. The school master was replaced by headmistress Miss Ellen J Arnold. The average attendance was less than fifty, with eighty-six school age children living within 3 ½ miles of the town.



Evening Journal
Wednesday 20th April

PETERSBURG, April 18.
Our school is closed at present, the school-master having disappeared and shows no sign of returning, he has been heard of in the neighborhood, but as far as I hear no one has taken any trouble about him although it is rumoured that he is wandering about in a deranged state of mind. The Council have been communicated with and the appointment of another master asked.

Union Church
Photo - State Library of SA – Peterborough Collection Image B 61759

The church was proven to be too small for the number of children who were attending so the town residents lobbied to have a school built.

A public meeting was held on 29th October 1881 to discuss the wants of the town.

- *An animated discussion ensued as to whether the site for the school was central enough. It was argued that the site was situated on high ground and in a healthy position and they had to look to the health of their children above all. It was estimated that there were now around eighty children who could attend school. The average attendance was between forty-five and fifty, and the old building could not possibly accommodate any more than already attended.*

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The Government was spending nearly £3,000 on buildings including a new school, post office and police station and cells. £1,200 was for the new school which could accommodate eighty students, £850 for the police station and cells and £750 for the post office and telegraph station. The Board of Advice for the district has settled on allotments 241, 242, 243, and 244 in Petersburg North for the school. This land was purchased from Mr Rohde for £50.

Tenders for the Government School at Petersburg were called for by Monday 9th May and Messrs G & W Sara and Duncan's tender of £1098-12 was accepted on 23rd May. Sara & Duncan of Koorunga also built the Railway Station in 1880.

*Adelaide Observer
Saturday 10th June 1882*

Architect-in-Chief's Department.—Erection of a school and residence at Petersburg, G. & W. Sara and Dunstan, £1,098 12s.

The new Petersburg State School and a four roomed residence was completed in December 1882 and following a final inspection in March, Mr Inglis the head teacher and his students were able to move into the school building. The school had a capacity for 80 children.



*Petersburg State School - 1883
Photo – Peterborough Library History Room*

The enrolments of the state school had been around one hundred for the past four years and in 1887 they had increased to 150 pupils. Many cases of ophthalmia were reported and this had kept the attendance down to about 50. Mr Inglis, Mr Hardy and Miss Inglis (sewing and fancy work) had their hands full when all attended.

By 1891 the town population had increased and there were complaints made about the inadequate accommodation at the State school, as the attendance greatly exceeded the number of scholars the school could hold. The school year opened at the end of January with Mr D O'Leary, late of Georgetown as head teacher.

The Petersburg Council inspected the conditions at the state school. The school was originally built for 80 students and there were now nearly double that attending.

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With the additions to the Petersburg State School still not forthcoming the increasing population of the town made the accommodation even more cramped. Many lessons were held outside, and sanitation was very low.

The overcrowded state school had not had its promised additions, and in November 1891, the Petersburg Council decided to again communicate with the Minister of Education to try to resolve the matter.

The government agreed to arrange for a room to be used by the state school to accommodate the children due to the overcrowding at the school. The council decided that the school could have use of the town hall for school purposes in the daytime.

Finally, by January 1892 the enlargement of the school was in progress, and the education department had rented a three-roomed house adjoining the school, for use until the additions were completed, rather than using the town hall. The additions of two classrooms which had progressed slowly would increase the capacity of students from 80 to 200.

The enlargements at the state school had finally been finished and a building with two new classrooms had been added. The original room and teacher's residence had not been repaired or improved since its erection and was still in a terrible state.

THE PETERSBURG SCHOOL.

Petersburg, September 9.
In reference to statements in "Hansard" it should be known that the Petersburg school-building at the outside has accommodation for only eighty children, whilst 122 were present to-day. On the roll there are 147, or nearly twice the number for which the school was built. The average attendance during July and August was 100 per day. The size of the building is 36 ft. by 20 ft. It is felt that in view of the leisurely manner in which the plans are being prepared that the summer will be over before any additions are completed.

*Adelaide Observer
Friday 12th September 1891*

PETERSBURG, November 17.
The apparently never-ending delay in proceeding with the long-talked-of additions to the State school was discussed at a meeting of the Town Council held last night, and it was resolved to again communicate with the Minister of Education and endeavor to induce him to visit the school personally. Many parents are now keeping their children away. The heat yesterday was intense.

*The Express and Telegraph
Tuesday 17th November 1891*



*Petersburg State School 1892
Peterborough Library History Room*

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Although the school had been enlarged the toilets had not.

The sanitary conditions of the outbuildings at the school unacceptable. The attendance at the school was now 180 and they had been waiting for nearly two years promised enlargement.

Petersburg Times
Friday 20th January 1893

SANITARY MATTERS AT THE SCHOOL.—The Central Board has directed the attention of of the local authorities to the unsanitary condition of the outbuildings at the State School and the facts disclosed reflect the utmost discredit on the Education Department. No increase in this accommodation has been made since the time when the attendance roll numbered 25—it has now reached 180. In addition to this, there seems little doubt but the tank from which the supply of water is drawn from the school, is contaminated from its proximity to the foul cess-pits. For some time past sickness amongst children has been unusually prevalent and it seems very probable that the disgraceful state of affairs at the school is largely to be blamed for this. The matter will be referred to more fully next week.

Even with the additional building several years ago the conditions at the state school had not improved with overcrowding a major issue. The school buildings could accommodate 200 students and there were almost 300 enrolled. There were only three teaching staff at the school as the fourth teacher had left and was not replaced. Many parents were refusing to send their children as they feared their children's health was in danger.

Dr Stevenson submitted a report on the government school. According to the report "*the school was overcrowded and the old part of the building badly ventilated, the air in the latter, on being tested showing 12 parts per 1000 of carbolic acid gas. The teachers and children frequently complained of headache and lassitude, which the doctor altogether attributed to the crowded and unhealthy condition of the building.*"

After many complaints at the overcrowding of the state school, tenders had finally been called for the erection of two additional classrooms in January 1897. The enrolments were about 430 students, and the accommodation was for about 250.

The long-awaited additions to the Petersburg State School had been completed and were opened on Monday 7th September 1897.

PETERSBURG STATE SCHOOL.—The additions to the school which for some time have been in progress, are now complete, and reflect every credit on the contractors, Messrs Tuck Brothers, of Tarowie. The new portion, which will provide accommodation for 160 additional scholars, will be opened on Monday next. The rooms are fitted with the latest improvements as regards furniture, which has been provided by the department in no niggardly fashion. The additions include a gallery and an extra porch, whilst the general improvements in the appearance of the building is most marked. The present average attendance is over 300, the teaching staff comprising—Mr D. O'Leary (head teacher), Mr. H. McNicol, Misses Clarke and McMahon, Mr Brady and Miss O'Leary.

Petersburg Times
Friday 10th September 1897



Petersburg State School
Photo – Lionel Noble Collection

In 1898 a roomy play shed had been erected at the school by Messrs Tuck Bros. This and the other additions made the previous year had greatly improved the accommodation at the school.

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It was announced in December 1906 that continuation classes were to be established at Petersburg, Gawler, Moonta, Kapunda, Mount Gambier, Kadina and Port Pirie. Mr J Bills from the state school received a wire directing him to report to headquarters to test his qualifications to take charge in the projected continuation school. Forty pupils had signified their intention of attending.

An open day was held at the Petersburg State School on Friday 4th October 1907 with a large number of parents and friends attending. An splendid exhibition of fancy and other work was on view and unstinted praise was given for the children and teachers alike. There were 484 students enrolled and 341 of these undertook exams. 304 of these students were promoted, 33 of whom from the 6th Class, and it was hoped will qualify for the continuation class at the end of the year. The establishment of the continuation class, the formation of the school band and cadet corps were all great additions to the school. New classrooms were being built to accommodate the upper classes and would relieve the pressure of much needed accommodation.

After an eight year aggregation the additions to the state school of two classrooms and a new teacher's residence had been completed in 1908. The school had 480 children on the roll and even with the new accommodation the school was almost taxed to its full capacity. The additions were declared open by the Treasurer (Hon AH Peake) accompanied by the Commissioner of Crown Lands and Members for the District. The two new rooms were for the continuation class which would be known as a District High School.

The old head teachers house had been demolished after the new one was built.



*Original Petersburg State School building built in 1883 with the additional two classrooms for the High school class and new teachers house built in 1908
Photo – Lionel Noble Collection*

Students from the high school travelled to Jamestown to play a game of cricket in November 1910. The Jamestown Cricket Club kindly allowed the boys to use their pitch and matting. After losing two quick wickets, the Petersburg team made 191 with A. Ryan being bowled for 97 to end the innings. The local boys took the visitors home for dinner before starting their innings. Jamestown were all out for 24 with A. Davey 7 for 15 and Ryan 2 for 4. Jamestown were sent in to bat again this time only managing to score 18 with Sharley 5 for 6 and Chinner 5 for 6.

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The Petersburg High School held their fifth annual Speech day and prize distribution at the town hall on Wednesday 20th December 1911. Mr GH Oswald (assistant in charge) read the annual report with 54 students attending the school. Roy Davey was awarded Dux of the School and Marjorie Lewis was awarded Dux of the Primary School.

A farewell was held for Mr GH Oswald, assistant in charge of the High School in September 1915 as he had enlisted and was ordered into camp.

News had been received that George Oswald, of the local High School who was serving at the front, had been promoted to the rank of captain, and was awarded the Military Cross. He was serving with the 43rd Australian Infantry Battalion, 11th Brigade.

George Harry Oswald was severely wounded in the right thigh by a machine gun bullet before being hit by a shell. He died from wounds at the 61st Casualty Clearing Station near Daours, Somme, France, on 1st September 1918, age 30 years.

The playground at the Public School had been in unusable since the building of the drain in 1915 and the children had not been able to use it. The Minister for Education (Hon. Mr Harvey) visited the school on Wednesday 23rd October 1918 and he stated that he would find funds to rectify the problem. The school committee also asked about having shorthand and Typewriting taught at the High School, as scholars from the school had no chance to enter the examination for the clerical division of the railways unless they were conversant with those subjects.

A Commercial Training Centre had been set up at several country schools and in 1919 Peterborough High School could now offer book-keeping, shorthand, typing and business correspondence to their students. The teacher would also visit Jamestown two days a week to give lessons.

The pupils from the high school travelled to Jamestown in October 1921 to compete in the annual triangular contest between Peterborough, Jamestown and Gladstone High Schools. The two visiting teams were entertained at lunch and afternoon tea by the students and staff of the Jamestown High School and competed in tennis and cricket and a 100 yard footrace. Although the weather was dull and stormy, a most enjoyable time was spent by all. Peterborough was only successful in the cricket match against Jamestown, losing to Gladstone in cricket and both tennis matches.

A memorial tablet of the men who enlisted in the Great War from the Peterborough High School took place on Wednesday 20th December 1922 at 11:30am. The Mayor Mr George Phillips unveiled the memorial which had the names of 50 old scholars and teachers who enlisted with DJ Badger, R. E Dodman, AF Hass, RA Wilson, HP Crickley WT Hass, BJ Irwin, GH Oswald and W Clarke paying the supreme sacrifice.

In August 1923 a committee had been formed for the proposal of a high school in the town. The Mayor (Mr Phillips), Councillors Goudie, Jamieson and Dodd were to approach Mr Koch re securing land next to Victoria Park. This was unsuccessful.

Correspondence was received from the High School Committee asking the council to grant three-quarters of an acre of land in Jubilee Park for the erection of a new high school as per the terms of the lease they were unable to use any of the land at Victoria Park. It was resolved to write to the Minister of Education asking if it was the intent of the department to erect a new high school at Peterborough.

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By the beginning of 1924 the committee of the new high school were pleased to announce that the land for the school had been secured on the corner of Railway and Park Streets, facing Jubilee Park. The site was 3 roods – 9 perches (just under an acre) and cost £225.

“Provisions had been made on the Loan Estimates for the provision of a new High School at Peterborough,” said the Hon LL Hill (Minister of Education), in the reply to Mr S McHugh, in the Assembly on Tuesday 21st October. It was also announced that the Public School would be remodelled, and hoped that the work would begin during the present financial year. Finally the Minister of Education had approved the immediate purchase of a suitable permanent residence for the High School head-master.

New High School.

The committee of the above were very pleased to learn that the land for a new High School had been secured at the corner of Railway and Park Streets, facing Jubilee Park. It is a most suitable position and the block contains half an acre. The plans and specifications are in course of preparation and it is expected that the foundation stone will be laid in April or May. A domestic art class has been added to the High School this year, and pending the erection of the new building, this class will be conducted in the Lake Hall supper rooms.

*The Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 1st February 1924*

The Hon L L Hill (Minister for Education), the Director of Education, the Superintendent of Primary Education and the Federal and State Members of Parliament visited Peterborough and were tendered a civic reception by the corporation on Friday 27th March 1924. A public address in the Town Hall in the evening was attended by a large number of the public. On Saturday morning the visitors inspected the site of the new High School and the remodelling of the Primary School. The site chosen for the High School near Jubilee Park had been the second choice and the first choice which the vendor originally would not sell, had now become available. The vendor was now willing to sell 2 acres adjacent to Victoria Park for a High School. The Government purchased the more suitable site for the High School which comprised 2 acres and cost £400. The site was next to Victoria Park on the south side of the town, and the site near Jubilee Park was sold.

By April 1926 the plans and estimates were almost complete for the high school, and tenders would be soon called. The cost of the school was £8,500 and would be completed in 12 months.

*The Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 3rd April 1925*

town, near the hospital. This site the committee tried to get in the first place, but the vendor would not sell; now he had changed his mind and was willing to sell 2 acres for a High School. This latter site was ideal and the best. They wished the Minister to go on with the new building for the High School first, and then to remodel the Primary School. The building at present was taxed to its utmost, and, as the town was growing, it was essential that the High School building be gone on with. The progress of the railway made it imperative that more families would come here to reside, and consequently more children would attend the school.

The Mayor, representing the citizens, stated that the Minister knew the growth of the town. For the last two years 40 new homes had been erected and 15 were now in construction. The shortage of building land was the cause of not more houses being erected, but during the last 18 months 400 building blocks had been thrown open, and 250 sold; the building trade for the next few years would be very brisk. The schools now were overcrowded, and he trusted that the Minister would push on the new High School building as soon as possible, so as to relieve the pressure. When the Railway Department built their 50 cottages the population would still further increase.

A woman's basketball association had been formed in June 1926 and included five teams: Trojans, Spartans, Arcadians, Imperials and Gymnasiums. Matches would be played on Saturdays and the High School Courts at the Public School.

The remodelling of the State School had been given the go ahead and arrangements had been made by the Education Department to temporarily transfer the High School students to the Methodist Sunday School Hall where they would rent the hall and two classrooms.

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The Foundation Stone of the new High School was laid by the Premier (Hon Lionel L Hill) on Friday 17th September 1926.

A new House system was introduced in July 1927.

Two houses: Goode and Oswald named after Dr Goode and George Oswald, provided a good deal of interest, with points given for sport, School work and behaviour.

Marks were deducted for misdemeanours including late-comers.

The high school, known as the continuation school in 1907, with a roll call of 50, is now a separate concern with a roll call of 80. It is housed in the Methodist Hall, but soon will be transferred to its new habitation, which will be second to none in the State. Playground, cricket pitch, basketball ground, and gymnasium will be provided. As a centre it will teach domestic arts and woodwork, in addition to the ordinary school curriculum.

The Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 4 March 1927

At Peterborough High School the newly inaugurated house system is working well. It is creating much interest, enthusiasm, and keen competition. Marks are deducted for misdemeanours of various kinds, including latecomers. At the end of the first week Goode House led by 13 points from Oswald House.

The Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 19 June 1927

News
Thursday 3 February 1927

HIGH SCHOOL SPORTS

JAMESTOWN VISIT PETERBOROUGH

On Saturday last, February 26th, the local High School received a visit from their "friendly enemies," the students of Jamestown High School. Cricket and tennis matches were played, and the visitors suffered defeat in both. A pleasant morning was spent by all concerned, and the usual sporting spirit prevailed. During the cricket match, one of the Jamestown boys was struck on the head by a fast, rising ball. Luckily, he was not seriously hurt, and was able to resume his innings later on. Our visitors were taken to private homes for lunch, and returned to Jamestown at 2.31 p.m., vowing to turn the tables when we next meet. We extend our thanks to all who helped to make the matches a success, more especially the Cricket Association and the local tennis clubs, who so kindly allowed us the use of their playing areas.

The High School council negotiated with Mr Koch for the purchase of extra land for tennis courts.

The Peterborough Highschool moved into their new quarters on Tuesday 30th August. Many thanks to the hard work of the Head Master, Messrs HC Ind, JC von Bertouch, WB Edson, W McLaren, assisted by Messrs W Cherry, N Keats, AD Garwood, JC Dodman, L Love and several of the high school boys who took the matter in hand and during the holidays succeeded in levelling the rubbish and clearing the grounds of rubble from the building operations and grading the grounds.



Original Highschool building
Photo – Lionel Noble Collection

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Enrolments at the high school had reached 123 by the start of 1938 and more room was needed.

New classrooms were opened at the Peterborough High School on Friday 4th November 1938 by the Minister for Education Mr Jefferies and Director of Education Mr Adey. The High School committees had raised over £600 in the past ten years to help pay for the new rooms. The High School Old Scholars Association was formed.

In 1939 to encourage the students at the High School team spirit was fostered with the students being divided into four houses with points given for school work and sport. The final points were Adey 238 ½, Oswald 215 ½, Koch 213 ½, and Goode 144 ½.

Adey and Koch had been added to the existing teams of Oswald and Goode. Adey was named after the Minister for Education Mr WJ Adey and Koch was named after Mr JH Koch in recognition of his support to the high school.

The Garwood family established the AD Garwood Memorial award in memory of Mr Alfred Garwood a railway worker who died on 10th December 1943. The award was given as an annual prize for boys good citizenship. The Parent's Association awarded a similar prize for girls.

Peterborough High School competed in the recent Northern High Schools' Athletics contest at Jamestown on Wednesday 28 August 1946. More than 300 competitors from Jamestown, Peterborough, Booleroo Centre and Gladstone took part in the sports with Peterborough winning with 163 points. Peterborough had won the shield 10 out of 16 times and took possession of the shield. A new shield had been offered by donor Mr Murchland as there were now four teams in the competition.

NORTHERN HIGH SCHOOLS ATHLETICS CONTEST PETERBOROUGH HIGH WINS SHIELD. Many readers will remember the Triangular Sports Contests of the past. Owing to severe restrictions of travel during the war years, it was necessary to abandon these contests for several years. Last year, however, the contest was revived, but only two schools were able to compete, but at Jamestown on Wednesday, August 28, of this year, four schools competed in the contest, to be held annually, and in future to be known as the Northern High Schools Athletics Contests; the schools represented this year were Booleroo Centre, Gladstone, Peterborough and Jamestown High Schools.	Students from Peterborough travelled by train, while those from Booleroo Centre and Gladstone were fortunate enough to be able to hire their school buses for the day. In all about 300 competitors and spectators arrived from these three schools. Mr. D. Boucaut, Chairman of the Jamestown High School Council welcomed visitors. To this welcome, Messrs. M. I. Pyne, B. H. Sugg, and J. McCarthy responded on behalf of the various schools, then Mr. C. M. Griggs, B.Sc., Dip. Ed. (acting Superintendent of High Schools) declared the contest open. During the afternoon, some fine performances were put up in the various events. Particular credit in this respect should go to J. Harden of Peterborough High School for securing 5 firsts and putting up an excellent performance in the boys open high jump (5ft. 2in.). W. Purasche, of Peterborough, secured 3 firsts in boys under 14 events.
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Laura Standard
Friday 30 August 1946

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK – HIGH SCHOOL

The results were as follows:—

Boys under 13, 75 yards—D. Noblett (BC) 1, T. Burgess (G) 2, G. Treasure (G) 3. Girls under 13, 50 yards—G. Hughes (BC), P. Luck (P), G. Madex (P). Boys, Open, 88 Yards Hurdles—J. Haden (P), G. Abbott (J), L. Wakefield (G). Boys under 14, 100 yards—W. Pursche (P), D. Noblett (B), R. Noble (P). Girls under 14, 60 yards—S. Brown (P), S. Dunn (J), K. White (G). Boys under 15, 75 yards Hurdles—A. Saunders (G), K. Tannebring (P), R. Clift (J). Girls Overhead Ball—Jamestown, Gladstone, Booleroo. Boys Open 880 yards—D. Shakes (P), K. Fraser (B), J. Smith (B). Boys under 15, 100 yards—G. Gale (G), M. Gibbs (J), M. Smith (B). Girls Corner Spry—Jamestown, Peterborough, Gladstone. Boys under 14, 60 yards hurdles—W. Pursche (P), R. Fosdike (J), G. Lloyd (J). Girls Open 85 yards—G. Dawson (P), M. Potter (P), B. Gaghan (G). Boys Open 100 yards—J. Haden (P), D. Fuller (P), J. Whalan (G). Boys under 14, High Jump—W. Pursche (P), R. Noble (P), R. Clothier (G) 2. Girls under 15, 75 yards—M. Potter (P), C. Teague (P), D. Hawkins (J) and V. Woolford (G) dead heat 3. Boys Open Broad Jump—J. Haden (P) 17ft. 9in., D. Shakes (P), J. Saunders (G). Girls Ziz Zag Passing—Peterborough, Jamestown, Gladstone. Boys under 13, Straight Relay—Gladstone, Booleroo, Peterborough. Boys under 15 Broad Jump—M. Smith (B) 16ft. 2in., M. Gibbs (J), G. Gale (G). Girls Open Goal, Throwing—Peterborough, Jamestown, Gladstone tie. Boys Open 220 yards—J. Haden (P), D. Fuller (P), L. Wakefield (G). Boys under 14, 440 yards Circular Relay—Gladstone, Peterborough, Jamestown. Girls Open 60 Yards Hurdles

—G. Dawson (P), M. Potter (P), B. Gaghan (G). Girls under 15 50 yards Hurdles—C. Teague (P), B. Lawrie (P), D. Hawkins (J). Boys under 15 440 yards Circular Relay—Gladstone, Peterborough, Booleroo. Girls Open 440 yards Circular Relay—Peterborough, Gladstone, Booleroo. Boys Open High Jump—J. Haden (P) 5ft. 2in., J. Whalan (G), R. Clift (J). Girls Open Broad Jump—G. Dawson (P) 15ft., M. Potter (P), D. Hawkins (J). Girls under 15 Circular Relay—Peterborough, Gladstone, Booleroo. Boys under 15 High Jump—A. Saunders (G) 4ft. 11in., M. Gibbs (J), R. Clift (J). Boys Open 440 yards—M. Frick (G), K. Fraser (B), G. Abbott (J). Girls under 14 Straight Relay—Peterborough, Gladstone, Jamestown. Girls Basketball Relay—Peterborough, Booleroo, Jamestown. Boys under 15 220 yards—M. Gibbs (J), A. Saunders (G), G. Gale (G). Boys Open Circular Relay—Gladstone, Peterborough and Booleroo dead heat.

The aggregate of points allotted were—Peterborough 163, Gladstone 91, Jamestown 56, Booleroo Centre 41.

On behalf of the competing schools Mr. Griggs, in presenting the Murchland-Nicollie Shield to the two head prefects of Peterborough High School, spoke of the pleasure he derives from such contests and congratulated all competitors, whether they had won or lost, the winners for their fine performance and others for their sporting attitude throughout the contest. This Shield now becomes the property of Peterborough High School, as this school has won it ten times out of sixteen. This is at the suggestion of Mr. J. Murchland, one of the donors, who has generously offered to present another Shield for competition between the four schools in future.

Laura Standard
Friday 30 August 1946